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To whom it may concern,

I am a J.J. Sylvester Assistant Professor in the mathematics department at Johns Hopkins University. This is a recommendation letter in support of Altera Labs who are applying for TEDCO's Baltimore Innovation Initiative Pilot Program.

While as an instructor I have discrete feedback on individual student progress in the form of grades on various weekly assignments, in a large class setting (with potentially hundreds of students) I am not able to read each individual assignment in detail in order to identify specific course content that would help improve their individual grades. Indeed, assignment grading is often outsourced to graduate students with little time and or teaching experience to guide students directly. This issue in the delay of feedback in university level courses is precisely the gap that Altera Labs seek to address. I believe that their current work shows strong promise in providing students with continuous real-time feedback and guidance, a tool that would be indispensable to me as an instructor.

This fall semester Peter Seelman, CEO of Altera Labs, is a student in my Honors Analysis course, in which I am facilitating the use of early demo of their platform. This course provides a rigorous introduction to the concepts of calculus, which many students report as challenging, and requires significant time and effort to absorb the material presented. This has been mutually beneficial, allowing Altera Labs to validate their knowledge tracking capabilities and the mathlib-grounded Socratic tutor in a rigorous setting, while providing me with continuous feedback and insights on course topics that students are struggling with.

While the course Altera Labs are testing their demo on has around twenty students, since the platform requires little to no input from the instructor, I strongly believe that the platform has potential to scale to large-scale classes with hundreds of students. It is precisely because of this that I agreed to be the primary Faculty Champion for the Baltimore Innovation Initiative Pilot Program. I look forward to seeing the value of the Altera Labs platform applied to a large-scale foundational STEM course, which the funding from your program can help expedite.

For the reasons above I strongly support the application of Altera Labs with no reservations. I am hopeful that their platform will help to better shape university environments in the years to come.

Yours faithfully,

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